



WPS
CALLOUSNESS
OF THE ESTAB-
LISHMENT AND
POACHING MAY
SOON END THE
TIGER TRAIL

Fading Stripes

- In 2004, it was discovered that Sariska had no tigers. By 2008, all big cats were gone from Panna.
- The last tiger census of 2005 put the number of tigers in Panna at 34.
- A special investigative team found that officials had tried to camouflage the truth about Panna.
- There have also been six unexplained tiger deaths over the past six months in Kanha.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) sent by the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) to probe reports of the disappearance of tigers from Panna confirmed early this month that there weren't any male tigers left in the once-thriving tiger reserve. In a belated face-saving move, the state Government last week transferred directors of three national parks, including L.K. Chaudhary of Panna. The directors of Bandhavgarh and Kanha parks have also been transferred. It seems a cosmetic exercise though, as Chaudhary was posted only in August 2008. According to the Central SIT, the park was already devoid of the big cats by that time.

The 2002 tiger census reported that Panna had 20 tigresses, 14 tigers and a cub. In 2004, a CBI inquiry confirmed that all tigers in Panna were dead even as forest officials maintained that the striped cats were very much alive. In April 2004, Belinda Wright, head of the Wildlife Protection

Society of India, filed a writ petition with the Central Empowered Committee constituted by the Supreme Court. She highlighted the alarming loss of tiger population in the park due to poaching, extensive burning and quarrying.

After the Sariska tragedy hit the headlines, the Madhya Pradesh Forest Department had claimed in December 2005 that according to their last count in March that year, there still were 34 tigers in the park. P.K. Sen, the SIT's chief, however, suspects that tigers may have vanished from Panna altogether by the end of 2008. In March 2009, two tigresses were transported to Panna from Bandhavgarh and Kanha parks after being tranquillised. Wildlife officials were hoping to find mates for the lone surviving tiger in the reserve. Their drive to promote breeding in Panna was futile once it became clear that the 'lone surviving' tiger in Panna's wilderness had not survived the cull.

Late in April, a SIT team made up of S.P. Yadav, Joint Director of NTCA, and Qamar Qureshi, senior scientist of the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun, held extensive public hearings in villages and dwellings around Panna National Park. The denial by locals about tiger sightings flew in the face of the claims by authorities about the presence of the lone male tiger in Panna.

The 2002 census, based on pug mark identification, stated that there were three tigresses for every 100 sq km in Panna. Then in 2006, a census revealed there were three tigers for each tigress, an alarming reverse, technically impossible within such a short time. In May that year, locals reported being unable to sight even one striped cat. All the time, forest officials claimed otherwise.

In 2006, wildlife conservationist Raghunandan Singh Chundawat had warned the Government about the dwindling tiger population in Panna.